Paneer Tikka Masala

mild, creamy, restaurant-style

Serves: 3–4, with rice or naan
Time: about 1¾ hours: 45 min getting ready, 1 hour at the stove
Heat: mild: no hot chili

A Get everything ready › **B Marinate the paneer** › C Brown the paneer › D Make the sauce › E Finish

Read both sides before you shop and before you cook. Shop from **both** sides: side 2 adds ghee, bay leaf, tomato purée, cream, sugar, kasuri methi, rice or naan.

You need: 12-inch nonstick **sauté pan** with lid · electric **spice grinder** · **box grater** · knife · cutting board · **tongs** · **spatula** · measuring spoons · **2 measuring cups** · **medium bowl** · **2 small bowls** (label them ONION and SPICE) · plate · paper towels · can opener

TBSP = tablespoon (big spoon), tsp = teaspoon (small spoon). Use the spoon and cup amounts; the grams are for a kitchen scale.

⚠ **ALLERGY:** Contains milk and cashews (tree nut). Nut allergy? Use the nut-free swap before you shop.

A Get everything ready

about 25 min

PANEER ☐ check off as you measure

☐	1 pack paneer (12–14 oz)	340–400 g

WHOLE SPICES: GARAM MASALA

☐	1 **TBSP** coriander seeds	5 g
☐	1½ tsp cumin seeds	3 g
☐	¼ tsp cardamom seeds, hulled	1 g
☐	4 whole cloves	0.5 g
☐	2-inch cinnamon stick	2 g

FOR GRINDING AND GRATING

☐	15 cashews (plain, not flavored)	20 g
☐	½ cup hot water	120 g
☐	1½-inch fresh ginger	15 g
☐	4 medium garlic cloves	15 g
☐	1 medium onion	150 g

1. **Cut** the paneer into 1-inch cubes with the knife. Put them in the **medium bowl** (the *paneer bowl*) and cover with hot tap water to soften them during steps 2–5.
2. Break the cinnamon into bits. Put all the whole spices in the **cold, dry sauté pan**. On **medium-low**, stir with the spatula until they smell strong and the cumin is a shade darker, 3–4 min. **Tip them onto the plate** right away; heat off. Smoke or black bits? Start again on lower heat.
3. Fill the measuring cup with ½ cup **hot** tap water. Put the **cashews** in the **spice grinder** and press in 1-second pulses, shaking, 12–15 times, until a fine powder. Stop before it turns to paste. Tip it into the water to soak.
4. **Peel the ginger** by scraping it with a spoon edge. Press each garlic clove with the flat of the knife and peel it. On the **fine holes** of the **box grater**, grate both onto the cutting board, then scrape them into the **SPICE bowl**. Stop when a piece gets small.
5. Cut the ends off the onion and peel off the papery skin. Grate it on the **big holes** of the box grater onto the board, then scrape it into the **ONION bowl**.

B Marinate the paneer

15 min or longer

INTO THE PANEER BOWL

☐	4 **TBSP** plain Greek yogurt	65 g
☐	1 tsp Kashmiri chili powder	2.5 g
☐	½ tsp smoked paprika	1 g
☐	½ tsp table salt	3 g

INTO THE SPICE BOWL

☐	1 tsp Kashmiri chili powder	2.5 g
☐	½ tsp ground turmeric	1.5 g
☐	2 **TBSP** tomato paste	32 g

6. Hold the paneer back with the spatula and pour the water into the sink. **Pat the cubes very dry** on paper towels (wet paneer makes hot fat spit). Dry the bowl; paneer back in. Move **2 tsp** of the ginger-garlic from the SPICE bowl onto the paneer.
7. Grind the cooled spices in the **spice grinder**, shaking it, until fine like ground pepper, 30–45 sec: this is your fresh **garam masala**. Unplug. Spoon **1 tsp** onto the paneer and all but about **1 tsp** into the SPICE bowl. Leave that last 1 tsp in the grinder for step 18.
8. Add the yogurt, chili powder, smoked paprika and salt to the paneer. Fold gently with the spatula until coated. Put it in the **fridge** for 15 min (or up to a day).
9. Stir the chili powder, turmeric and tomato paste into the SPICE bowl to make a thick paste.

While the paneer marinates: put the rice to soak (rice step **R1**, side 2) and wash the grater and board. Then **turn the sheet over**.

ⓘ Shopping help

BEFORE YOU SHOP

- **Cardamom seeds, hulled** (labeled "decorticated"), **Kashmiri chili**, **kasuri methi** and the whole spices: Indian grocery or online. Only cardamom pods? Crack about 4 open and use the black seeds.
- **Passata** is smooth, strained tomato; any unsalted tomato purée works.

ⓘ Safety rules (read once)

- **Grinder:** wait for the blade to stop, then unplug it before opening or cleaning. The blade is sharp.
- Never heat the empty nonstick pan on high. Turn pan handles inward. Never leave a lit burner alone.

? Need a swap?

LOOK UP IF NEEDED

- **No ghee?** → Brown the paneer in 1 TBSP vegetable oil, and cook the onion in 2 TBSP butter.
- **No Kashmiri chili?** → Use sweet paprika, same amounts. Even milder, a little less red.
- **Want it spicy?** → Add ¼ tsp (0.5 g) cayenne to the SPICE bowl.
- **Nut allergy?** → Leave out the cashews and water, and add 2 TBSP (30 g) more cream.
- **Stick blender?** → After step 17, blend the sauce smooth in a tall jug (not in the pan).
- **Only regular yogurt?** → Use 3 TBSP (45 g); it's thinner.

Paneer Tikka Masala · Side 2: At the stove

A Get everything ready | B Marinate the paneer | C Brown the paneer | D Make the sauce | E Finish

C Brown the paneer

about 10 min

- ☐ 1 **TBSP** ghee — 13 g

My stove notes

FILL IN ONCE

Our stove: medium-high = ____ medium = ____
medium-low = ____ low = ____

10 Take the paneer out of the fridge. Turn on the stove fan. Heat the ghee in the sauté pan on **medium-high** until it shimmers, about 2 min. A test cube should sizzle right away.

11 With the **tongs**, let extra marinade drip back into the bowl and lay the cubes in one layer, not touching. ⚠ **Careful:** it spits. Lay each cube down away from you.

12 **Don't touch** until the bottoms have dark brown spots, about 2 min, then turn. Brown 2–3 sides, 6–8 min total; a few black spots give the smoky taste. Move the paneer to the plate. **Keep the leftover marinade.**

D Make the sauce

about 35 min

- ☐ 2 **TBSP** ghee — 26 g
- ☐ 1 leaf bay leaf — 0.2 g
- ☐ 1 tsp table salt — 6 g
- ☐ 1⅔ cups tomato purée or passata — 400 g

+ ONION bowl, SPICE bowl, marinade, cashew water

Cook the rice

You need a strainer, a small pot with a lid and a fork.

R1 **At step 9:** Rinse **1 cup (190 g) basmati** in the strainer until the water runs almost clear. Put it in the small pot with **1½ cups (360 g) water** and **½ tsp (3 g) salt** and leave it to soak.

R2 **At step 17:** Bring it to a boil on high, put the lid on, and turn to the **lowest** heat for **12 min**. Turn off the heat and leave the lid on for 10 min. Fluff with a fork.

Naan instead? → Warm it in a dry pan, 1 min per side.

13 Same pan, no need to wash it. Turn the heat to **medium**. Add the ghee and bay leaf and stir 15 sec.

14 Add the **onion** and the salt. Stir every minute until the liquid is gone and the onion is **golden brown and sticky**, 12–15 min. The color matters more than the clock. Browning too fast? Turn the heat down and add 1 TBSP water.

15 Turn the heat to **medium-low**. Add the **SPICE bowl** paste. Stir and scrape until it is darker red and doesn't smell of raw garlic, about 2 min.

16 Add the tomato purée and scrape in the **leftover marinade**. Turn the heat to **medium**. Cook, stirring and scraping the bottom often, until darker and thick with **red oil at the edges**, 8–12 min. ⚠ **Careful:** it pops. Keep the lid tilted on and lift it away from you.

17 Stir the **cashew water** (the cashews sink) and pour it in. When it bubbles, turn to **low** and tilt the lid on. **Simmer** (small, lazy bubbles), stirring every 3 min, until it coats the spatula, about 10 min. **Start the rice now** (rice step R2, left). Take out the bay leaf.

E Finish

5 min, then 10 min rest

- ☐ ½ cup heavy cream — 120 g
- ☐ 1 tsp sugar — 4 g
- ☐ 2 tsp kasuri methi (dried fenugreek) — 1 g

+ the 1 tsp garam masala left in the grinder

After you eat

LATER

Leftovers: into the fridge within 2 hours; they keep 3–4 days and taste even better the next day.
Grinder: grind 2 TBSP dry rice for 10 sec, throw the rice out, unplug, and wipe or rinse the bowl (never put the motor in water). Soak the pan while you eat.

18 Keep it on **low**. Stir in the cream, the sugar and the last 1 tsp of garam masala from the grinder. **Crush the kasuri methi** between your palms over the pan. Let it come back to a gentle bubble only.

19 Fold in the paneer and any juices on the plate. Heat until hot, about 3 min. **Turn off the heat.** Put the lid on and let it rest 10 min.

20 **Taste** (blow on the spoon first). Flat? Add a pinch of salt. Sour? Add a pinch of sugar. Serve.

✓ **Done when:** the sauce is thick, creamy and orange-red and coats a spoon, and the paneer is soft with browned edges.

If this happens...

LOOK UP IF NEEDED

Spices won't grind fine	Shake the grinder while it runs, in 10-second bursts.
Paneer sticks to the pan	It isn't ready to turn. Wait 30–60 sec; it lets go once it's browned.
Onion browns too fast	Turn the heat down, add 1 TBSP water and scrape.
Spice paste sticks or darkens fast (step 15)	Add the tomato purée right away.
Sauce too thick	Stir in water, 2 TBSP at a time.
Sauce too thin	Simmer a few minutes longer with no lid, before the paneer goes in.
Sauce looks grainy or oily after the cream	It boiled too hard. Take it off the heat and stir in 2 TBSP more cream.
Tastes flat / sour / salty	Flat: add a pinch of salt. Sour: add a pinch of sugar. Salty: add more cream and a splash of water.